What We Do In The Daylight

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

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Friendship is Magic, Therapy, secret life, talking about feelings, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Catra's finally starting to be okay, Emotional Support, Date Night, Also fluff, lots of fluff, Post-Canon, Canon Compliant

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Part 4 of Days to Come

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by JustACuteWriteyLesbian

Summary

Catra actually had a very busy day planned. The two of them would spend most days together, working on the reconstruction or running off to save the day. Again. They did not have much time to themselves and when they did, they spent it together, mostly trying to recover from the work they were doing and simply enjoying each other's company. But sometimes, Adora would have She-Ra things to do or boring meetings to attend and Catra would opt out. She told Adora that she was going to take the day off and lounge about, but rarely was she being entirely truthful when she said it. In fact, she had a bit of her own secret life when Adora was away. It felt… good. To have something that was her own. To be someone, even for a short time, outside of Adora. Not that she was going to give Adora the satisfaction of telling her that. Not yet.

Catra takes a day off and has several sweet conversations with various friends.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Adora breathed in the new day with enthusiasm. She was just stirring from a restful sleep and she could feel the soft sunlight warming her shoulders streaming in from the balcony. She reached across the bed, hands searching for a soft, warm body, but the only thing they found were cool sheets. “Catra?” she grumbled as she cracked open her eyes to find that the bed was, indeed, empty. She stared in confusion for just a second before her eyes widened, her heart beat faster, and she sat upright. “Cat-“ As she sat up, her eyes locked with Catra's.

She was lounging at the foot of the bed, right by Adora’s feet. It looked like she had been awake for a while, which was surprising; Adora was usually the first to rise. Catra was dressed and looked ready for the day. Her back leaned against the bedpost of their new, much larger bed, one leg propped up on the mattress, one lazily hanging off the side. Her tail flicked playfully, and the adoring look in her mismatched eyes literally took Adora’s breath away. “-ra.” She finished, exhaling the word.

Catra fixed her with an absolutely disarming smile before uttering the most brazen, sultry,

“Hey, Adora.”

Adora felt her cheeks redden. Her only response was a dazed and breathy, “Hey.”

Catra’s smile widened impishly. “So, I’m the first thing on your mind when you wake up, huh? Good to know.” she said, flicking

her tail playfully.

Adora rolled her eyes and grinned back at her. “Don’t read too much into it.”

Catra laughed. “Oh, I’m reading the whole book, babe.”

“Oh, so I’m *babe* now, huh?” Adora shot back, grinning.

“What? No. Adora, do you need your hearing checked?” Catra deflected.

“Well, not all of us have ears the size of… y’know, I mean, they’re really big.” Adora replied, giggling.

Catra laughed heartily. “You are so dumb.” she jabbed affectionately, shaking her head.

Adora smirked. “You’re the one who fell in love with me. What does that make you?”

“Adora,” Catra said with mock hurt. “Those sound like fighting words.”

They stared at each other intensely for a moment before Adora spun to reach for the pillow behind her, but Catra (as always) was too quick. She lunged for the other pillow and before Adora could get a swing in, Catra whapped her across the face with it. Adora retaliated and before long, the pillows burst, spewing feathers all over them. Catra squealed and Adora took the opportunity to rush her, tackling her onto the mattress. Once again, Catra was too quick. As they fell upon the sheets, she grasped Adora and used the momentum to flip them so that she was on top. She pinned Adora's arms and legs under her, rendering her helpless. Adora struggled and Catra stared down at her with a smirk.

"Like you could ever beat me in a fair fight." She said, holding tight to Adora's writhing hands.

"Because you always cheat!" Adora rebutted, giggling, ceasing her pointless struggling.

"You mean using everything I have and turning it to my advantage? Yeah, I think only losers call that cheating, Adora." Catra replied, her smirk becoming more unbearably smug.

Adora blew a feather from her face and looked at the mess splayed across the bed. "We're going to need new pillows." She said in the tone of a child that knew they were in trouble.

"And sheets. And maybe a new bedframe." Catra remarked, her eyes directing Adora's to the large rips in the fabric underneath them and the long, deep claw marks branded on the headboard. Adora blushed.

“Glimmer’s going to kill me.” She said.

“She’ll get over it.” Catra assured, rolling her eyes.

“You don’t understand, Catra. She’s going to have *questions*. What am I going to tell her? You know how bad I am at acting!” Adora whined.

Catra laughed. “Well, at least you’re not as fragile as the pillows.” She said, finally releasing Adora’s hands and lightly touching a spot on Adora’s neck where she knew for a fact there was a light bite mark just the night before. It seemed that She-Ra’s healing powers were working overtime.

Adora smiled at her with lidded eyes and Catra could not resist. She lowered her head, bringing her nose down to brush against Adora’s. She felt Adora’s body squirm under her in a much different sort of way and reveled in the blush that bloomed across Adora’s cheeks. Adora slowly lifted her head. She could feel Catra exhale a hot breath against her lips. They both froze when they heard a loud knock on the door.

“Adora! Adora, are you awake?” Glimmer’s voice carried from the hallway.

Catra groaned into Adora’s shoulder.

“At least she knocked.” Adora said, chuckling, twining her fingers through Catra’s short hair.

Catra began to pull away but Adora’s hands held her fast. “Ignore it.” She pleaded gently. Catra looked at her with surprise, then something much softer. She leaned down again into Adora’s face and Adora trailed her fingers over the soft fur on her neck. Glimmer pounded harder against the door. “I can hear you two in there! Adora, if you make me sit through this meeting alone, I swear I’ll – “

“Okay, I’m awake! I’m up!” Adora called, then looked up at Catra in a panic. “Wait, is it already that late? How long did I sleep?”

“Fifteen minutes, Adora! If you’re not there I’m poofing in there and dragging you out!” Glimmer said in a half-amused, half-exasperated tone before the distinct sound of her teleport signaled her retreat.

Before Adora could say anything else, Catra slinked off of her and began walking toward the balcony.

“Catra…” Adora started, lifting herself off the bed and following after her.

“It’s fine, Adora. Really.” Catra called back, not turning to look at her. Her tone was genuine but Adora knew her better. “Go do your thing. Go be a her – “ Catra’s sentence was cut short by Adora spinning her around and capturing her in a hungry kiss. Catra quickly fell into it, closing her eyes and wrapping her hands around Adora’s hips.

After a long moment, Adora pulled back slightly, running her fingers through the thin fur on Catra’s face and gazing intently into her eyes. “Hey, I told you. You come first.”

Catra felt an unexpected swell of emotion and she leaned forward, kissing Adora again tenderly. As they pulled apart, Catra ran a longing hand up Adora’s side but said, “Go on, go get ready for your big meeting.”

Adora did not move for a moment, but simply stared into Catra’s loving eyes, brushing her thumbs over her cheeks. “You should come. The Star Siblings are here! And we’re using Bow’s tech to phone in diplomats from other planets! We’re finally going to know what’s been going on in the rest of the universe!”

“Adora I can literally not think of anything more excruciating. Sit in a boring meeting and discuss intergalactic politics with a bunch of huffy strangers? No thanks, I think I’ve had my fill of that.” Catra scoffed, rolling her eyes and flicking her tail.

“Aw, come on. They’re serving brunch.” Adora coaxed.

"Worse." Catra replied. "And I'd probably just distract you with my witty remarks and stunning good looks and we'd end up giggling through the whole thing. Then Sparkles would probably teleport me to the top of a mountain and leave me there and I would *really* prefer to stay on her good side."

"She would not!" Adora said almost indignantly, a smile tugging at her lips. "I'd make her go back and get you."

Catra half-laughed, half-scoffed. "Adora, really. I'm good. I'll be here when you get back, okay?" She walked back to the bed, stretching idly before sitting down on the mattress.

"Oh, so, what, you're just gonna wait here for me all day? This is probably going to take a while."

"Of course not. I'll probably nap, maybe get up and stretch, then nap again." Catra replied with a smirk.

"Wow, having no responsibilities really suits you." Adora said, sarcasm dripping from her words.

"I think I've found my calling." Catra answered. She leaned back, crossing her hands behind her head, and closed her eyes.

Adora *pft*'d at her and joined her on the bed, scrutinizing her. "You do look more relaxed." she observed.

“You should try it sometime.” Catra remarked. Her body and mind were, indeed, very much relaxed, more than they had been in a long time. Though, not from doing nothing. Catra actually had a very busy day planned. The two of them would spend most days together, working on the reconstruction or running off to save the day. Again. Often they would find themselves helping Entrapta with modifications to Darla or retrofitting Prime’s tech into… well, whatever Entrapta deigned necessary. Recently they had gotten teleporters up and running in each kingdom so that the Princesses could come and go, and supplies could be easily delivered wherever they were needed.

They did not have much time to themselves and when they did, they spent it together, mostly trying to recover from the work they were doing and simply enjoying each other’s company. But sometimes, Adora would have She-Ra things to do or boring meetings to attend and Catra would opt out. She told Adora that she was going to take the day off and lounge about, but rarely was she being entirely truthful when she said it. In fact, she had a bit of her own secret life when Adora was away. It felt… good. To have something that was her own. To be someone, even for a short time, outside of Adora. Not that she was going to give Adora the satisfaction of telling her that. Not yet.

“That’s not a bad idea.” Adora said thoughtfully.

“What?” Catra asked absently, pulling her wandering thoughts back to the present.

“Relaxing. We should make some time to relax. Maybe go to Mystacor. They have a beach and this thing called a spa. We should go there together.” Adora said, with that infuriatingly hopeful, beautiful smile of hers.

Catra could not help but smile in return. “Sounds great.” She replied. She had no illusions that Adora had any intention to actually relax but… it was a nice thought. Maybe they would make it happen. Why not? The war was over, they had saved the entire *universe*, and they deserved some time to themselves.

“Hey, didn’t Glimmer say she was going to teleport in here and get you if you were late to this thing?” Catra asked wryly.

Adora gasped and jumped up from the bed to the dresser, hastily throwing on her clothes as Catra laughed after her. Right on cue, Glimmer teleported into the room just as Adora was straightening her jacket. “Adora!” she called.

“I’m here! I’m ready!” Adora said, hurriedly putting her hair up in the mirror. Glimmer tapped her foot and rolled her eyes at Catra who shot her a playful wink.

“Okay, let’s go!” Adora said running over to Glimmer. The queen gave her a once over to ensure she was presentable before nodding, apparently satisfied. Then they were gone, leaving nothing but a few stray sparkles in their wake.

Catra sighed but before she could stand, Adora and Glimmer were back in a flash, standing right in front of her. Catra squealed and Adora shouted, “I forgot something really important!” before taking Catra’s face urgently in her hands and leaning in for a short but sweet kiss. “I love you.” She said when they parted, blushing lightly.

Catra mirrored her shy, loving smile. “Love you, too.”

Adora stepped back to where Glimmer was watching, and with a roll of her eyes and a soft smirk, she teleported them out of the room.

“Breathe in,” Perfuma instructed. Catra counted in her head. “And out” Catra did so, willing the tense muscles in her back and tail to relax. She had been seeing Perfuma off and on for the past month or so. Perfuma had repeatedly offered her assistance in helping Catra unblock her trauma issues. And abandonment issues. And anger issues. Catra had a lot of issues. And that wasn’t a secret, everyone in Brightmoon (and maybe even all of Etheria) had some sort of firsthand experience with being on the receiving end of Catra’s issues. And she was working on it, she was. For a while she had told herself that she had to figure this out on her own, that she didn’t need help with this. She was brilliant and capable after all. But after a particularly bad incident in which Catra had run off and hurt herself in a fit of terror and self-loathing, she realized that, brilliant and capable as she was, this was something she had no idea how to handle. She had no experience, no frame

of reference. Eventually she (begrudgingly) admitted to herself that she needed help. So here she was. Sitting with Perfuma. Breathing. In and out.

They sat in a wooded nook just outside of Brightmoon. The sun beamed down through cracks in the leaves above them and to the side was a weathered stone bench and a couple of crumbling pillars. The ground was dotted with old, mossy stepping stones, as if there had been a sort of pavilion here at one point. Wild magic ivy with small, luminescent blue flowers reached up the pillars and tree trunks, illuminating the shaded space with a soft glow. Beyond the pillars was a small overlook where they could see the Whispering Woods stretching out before them.

Melog lay contentedly in a sunny spot on the stone bench, dozing and purring softly. Catra sat cross-legged in the lush grass and Perfuma sat beside her. Their eyes were closed and Perfuma was attempting to guide her through a meditation, which so far had mostly just been breathing. There was also some junk about visualizing her thoughts as bubbles and letting them drift away, and some body scanning, which mostly involved going through all of her muscles from the tips of her ears down to her toes and letting them relax. Somehow Catra had expected more. Perfuma had made it clear that *talking* was also an option but Catra… wasn't sure she was ready for that yet. And so, they sat and breathed. And it was helping, Catra admitted to herself grudgingly. "Breathe in…" Perfuma coaxed, noticing Catra getting lost in thought. The silence, the scenery, the comfort of fresh air filling her lungs and the exhalation of her tension and fear felt… well, it was working. Maybe. A little. "And out."

As they sat, Catra found her thoughts wandering to familiar places, good and bad. Adora, her smile, the sound of her laughter,

the way she would pout when Catra had said something particularly snarky. Her friends (they were now, weren't they?), Bow and Glimmer. She admitted Bow's *incessant* positivity was growing on her, and she found herself falling into sassy banter with Glimmer more and more often. Then there was Scorpia. Catra was trying very hard to be a better friend, and Scorpia gently guided her through it. Scorpia was implacably gracious and Catra was continually grateful. And Mermista… things were still tense there. Mermista had been the least forgiving of the princesses, and honestly, Catra didn't blame her. Sileneas was reduced to rubble at Catra's command; it had been her idea. Even so, they were civil with each other when they had to be, and they were even starting to indulge in shooting cheeky quips at one another on very special occasions. It was how they expressed their affection, and they both saw that in each other. They had an understanding; it was a start. And Frosta… she wasn't sure about Frosta. She was awkward and easily excited and *loud,* but she was young and Catra had to admit, it was… nice. Watching her grow into her own with the supportive friends – the *family* – she never had… sometimes she would think about it and her heart filled with warmth. And envy. And of course Perfuma was… well, Perfuma was doing this.

"Breathe in… and out."

Then there were the bad things. Black shadows and dark magic. The smell of metal and smoke. Glowing red eyes glaring at her as she suffocated. Her own face shattered and warped, the darkness that always thrashed inside of her finally consuming her. Adora, her tears, the sound of her scream, the way she *looked* at Catra sometimes, as if expecting the monster inside to finally show its face. And always, always, the sickly green glow, sharp ancient eyes staring into her mind, into her soul. That voice that called out to her from her nightmares, calling her by name, then calling her by the name he gave her. A chorus of the same voice surging

and swelling around her, a sea of glowing green eyes staring at her as she drowned, *cast out the shadows, cast out the shadows…*

Catra's hand almost reached up to cover the small scar on the back of her neck, but she stopped herself. "Breathe in," Perfuma said gently, noticing Catra's movement and the way she shuddered. "And out." Catra tried but slowly, she began to spiral down the rabbit hole she always fell into. The silence was suddenly deafening. Panic began to rise in her. Her breathing had grown erratic and out of her control. She heard someone calling her name as if from far away. Then she heard *his* voice. "Catra." She could not contain the thoughts that viciously swirled around in her head, that sickly green glow, the gentle, possessive touches, her hair falling in a thick halo at her feet, and that *voice*. It called to her ceaselessly, coaxing her out of her own body. She could not resist. She tried. "Catra?" she heard him say right next to her. Something was different. No, it wasn't his voice, it was someone else. "Catra? Catra!"

She opened her eyes gasping for air. Her hand clasped the back of her neck protectively. "Catra…" Perfuma said gently. Catra looked at her, startled. She stared in confusion for a moment, catching her breath, before scowling and quickly leaping to her feet. She stalked over to the stone pillars and looked out at the woods sprawling out before her. She caught herself scanning the horizon for any glitch, any inconsistency that would give away the illusion. "No, this is real." She thought, surprised by the sound of her own voice as she realized she had said it out loud. Melog mewed at her comfortingly and brushed its head against her legs. She reached down and scratched them behind the ears, her other hand still grasping the back of her neck.

“Catra.” She heard Perfuma call, her voice tinged with a concern that for some reason enraged her.

“I’m fine.” She said quickly, rubbing her neck one last time and lowering her hand. “This isn’t working. This never works, it’s always the same.”

“It will if you give it time.” Perfuma said. “Trauma is complicated. This meditation is meant for you to be able to separate these thoughts from yourself. These thoughts aren’t you. Practice and visualization can help you externalize them and dissociate from them in a healthy way.”

“Well it’s not working!” Catra shot angrily, turning to glare at her. She quickly backtracked and took a moment to calm herself down, doing the stupid breathing thing. *In and out. In… and out.* “Sorry.” She went on. “I know it’s not your fault. You didn’t do this to me. I just… I need this to stop. I need to be able to sleep without hearing his voice, I need him gone, and… and I know he’s *gone*, but…” She trailed off and found her hand had found its way back up to the scar on her neck. She quickly brought it down.

“Well… it would probably help more if you tried… externalizing these thoughts in a different way.” Perfuma hinted with all the subtlety of jackhammer.

“You mean *talk* about it?” Catra scoffed.

“Yes.” Perfuma replied, dropping all pretense. “Catra, if you want this to go away…”

Catra didn’t say anything, she just looked down at the ground angrily until she felt her anger gradually start to recede. She breathed. In… and out. She pictured Adora’s face, her stupid, dopey, hopeful grin. The way she looked at her with nothing but love and understanding. *Breathe in… and out.* She saw the look on Adora’s face a few weeks ago when she had awoken from a nightmare, claws slashing blindly at everything around her, leaving deep marks all over Adora’s body. *Breathe in… and out.* She couldn’t keep doing this. She couldn’t keep hurting Adora, or herself.

Catra wanted to be better, she wanted to *feel* better, or at least not feel the way she felt all the time. But she had grown so comfortable here. This feeling felt like her home. She didn’t know how to leave; she didn’t know where she would go if she did. She thought of Adora. How Adora would hold her when she had nightmares. How she would kiss her gently. How she would tell her she loved her and how her heart filled with something like absolute surrender when she said it. *That’s my home,* she thought. This had to stop. She *needed* to get better. She would *not* let herself destroy this too. If not for herself then… *Do it for her*. She took one more steadying breath, then slowly sat down in front of Perfuma, her eyes glued resolutely to the grass in front of her. She was silent for a long time before sighing and looking intently down at her hands.

“When I was chipped I… I felt… It was um… it was…”

Perfuma just nodded and waited for Catra to continue.

"It was… honestly it was… it felt… *good*." She said finally.

Perfuma did not look surprised, just concerned. Catra suspected she had heard this before from other victims of the chip. "Good?" she asked.

"Yeah, like… when I was chipped I… I felt… it was so… peaceful. Everything else just slipped away and I was… I wasn't happy. I'm happy now, I know what that's like. But I was… I don't know. I wasn't… angry, or miserable. All that was just… gone." Catra said. She noticed her trembling hand had returned to its place at the back of her neck, but she let it rest there for now. Perfuma waited patiently and her silence coaxed Catra on.

"And I could see what was going on, I understood, but I couldn't… I couldn't stop it. I didn't *want* to. And I could… *feel* his hands on me and it made me… angry, but also… it made me feel… safe. And I knew it was wrong, I hated him, but I… I…" Catra's voice cracked and she could feel hot tears streaming down her face.

"Catra, Prime is gone. He can't hurt you anymore." Perfuma offered soothingly.

"You don't get it!" Catra cried, choking back a sob. "I… I *miss* it."

At this, Perfuma looked taken aback. She quickly composed herself, concern and understanding filling her gentle eyes.

"I don't miss *him*." Catra said shakily. "I miss… the chip. I miss feeling… feeling like I was okay, *for once in my life*. I miss… I miss feeling like that." Catra chuckled darkly, punctuated by her gasping breaths. "Isn't that sick? He used me to get to Adora, just like *everyone else* and I miss it!"

Catra collapsed into her own hands and wept, and Perfuma let her. She watched Catra cry for a long while, until her sobs slowed into soft sniffles and she had run out of tears. When Catra finally looked back up at her, she saw the quiet fear in Catra's eyes. She was quick to soothe it.

"Thank you, for being so open with me, Catra. I want you to know that what you're feeling is normal. There's nothing wrong with the way you feel, not ever. It's what you do about it that counts." She said gently. She paused, carefully composing her next question. "Is there… maybe something in your life now that makes you feel that way? That makes you feel safe and loved?"

That was easy. "Yeah. Adora makes me feel that way. It's not the same, but it's… I don't know. Not as good and also… better?" She said sniffing lightly, wiping remnant tears away with the back of her hand.

"Anything else?" Perfuma prompted.

Catra thought about it. Melog nudged her shoulder lightly with its snout. “Melog makes me feel that way. And I guess… I guess I feel that way sometimes with other people. With Bow and Glimmer and Scorpia. And I…” she paused, struck with realization. “I guess I… feel that way now.”

Perfuma smiled at her and Catra had an inkling she was resisting the urge to say *I told you so*. “Catra, I want to assure you that anything you say here stays here. Whatever you tell me in this space stays between us. And if you want we can… maybe try this again?”

Catra took a long, deep breath, composing herself. She absently petted Melog and stared at the ground for a long moment before saying,

“Yeah… okay.”

“Come on,” Netossa taunted. “I know you can do better than that.”

Catra clawed and struggled her way out of Netossa’s magical net. She stood quickly and lunged again, closing in on Netossa, weaving from side to side to avoid more nets. Now this was

therapy, Catra thought excitedly. She reveled in the way her heart raced, the adrenaline coursing through her system. This was familiar. This she knew. No talking, no *feelings*, just a singular goal: be the last one standing.

She had started sparring with Netossa a while ago. It was a good outlet for her. It kept her from getting too antsy. All Catra had ever known was violence. She had always been fighting, fighting for her life, fighting for her right to exist. Since the war ended, there had been no fighting, no violence, no conflict. After about a month of peace, Catra had felt like she was about to crawl out of her skin. She had gotten paranoid, her body reacted to imaginary enemies everywhere, despite her mind telling her that she was safe, that she was home. She was anxious, she lashed out, mostly at Adora.

It was Bow who had suggested that maybe she needed an outlet for... everything. *Something to help you feel prepared. To feel safe,* he had said. And it helped. Just a little, but it helped. Her combat skills were as sharp as ever and the exercise was doing her good. Adora was a fine sparring partner but she was so busy all the time. And she pulled her punches, Catra could tell. They both did if she was being honest with herself. Even as She-Ra (especially as She-Ra), Adora could never give Catra the real fight she craved, not with how things were now. At least she didn't have to worry about Netossa holding back.

Catra weaved to the side to avoid a net, running up a large pillar and launching herself from it, leaping toward Netossa, claws at the ready. Netossa just smirked at her and Catra suddenly felt her leg catch on something. She hit the ground with a loud *oof!* She looked back to see that the net Netossa had thrown at her had caught her foot and tethered her to the pillar. She heard a shout

and as she looked up, she saw Netossa launching her own aerial attack at her, her fist raised, ready to come down on Catra's face. Catra felt her muscles tense as she closed her eyes and braced for the blow. Netossa landed hard in front of her, her fist stopped just an inch from Catra's nose.

"You froze up." She said, standing straight, crossing her arms, and smirking.

Catra rolled her eyes. "I don't freeze up." she scoffed.

"Uh, but you just did." Netossa said. "I didn't have you pinned. You could've dodged or blocked, but you froze."

Catra hissed and glared down at the ground.

"Is something bothering you?" Netossa asked crouching down to try to get a good look at Catra's face. Catra just scowled at her. "Is it Adora? Did something happen with you two?"

Catra sat up and slashed at the magical net still holding her by her foot. "No, everything's great with me and Adora. Not that it's any of your business." She growled.

"Then what is it? You've obviously got something on your mind and it's slowing you down." Netossa said, standing again and offering a hand to Catra.

Catra indignantly ignored Netossa's outstretched hand and got herself off the ground, brushing herself off. "It's nothing, I'm fine. Look, I think I've already met my quota of talking about feelings today so can we just fight?" she said crossing her arms, not looking at Netossa.

"Ooooh, is *that* what you were doing with Perfuma? Aw man. Guess I owe Spinny dinner." It was Netossa's turn to scowl.

Catra stared at her. She felt a hot flush of self-conscious anger build up in her chest. Netossa noticed her glare and was quick to reassure her. "Hey, don't worry. Your secret's safe with me."

Catra forced herself to relax. *Breathe in… and out.* "Are we gonna fight or what?" she hissed.

Netossa looked at her, sizing her up, then grinned slyly. "Fine, but if I win, you tell me what's bothering you."

Catra glared at her for a moment, weighing her options. Netossa had already won a few rounds, not that anyone was counting (except they both definitely were). She finally decided *nope,* and quickly turned around and began to walk away. Netossa ran after her and stepped in front of her, chuckling. "Hey! I'm just messing with you. We don't have to talk about it if you don't want to."

Catra growled again. “I don’t… it’s not… I’m not…” she started, then paused, gathering her thoughts. Surprisingly enough, Catra found herself thinking that maybe she *did* want to talk about it. Or perhaps she just realized that she *ought* to talk about it. This whole *emotional honesty* business was leaking into her sparring sessions. Catra wasn’t sure she liked it. But… Netossa was good with this stuff, right? Her relationship was the strongest and most stable Catra had ever seen. And Catra knew that she would probably need… ugh, *help* with this. She scowled, then sighed, before finally saying, “It’s… Adora.”

Netossa shot her another smug smirk. “Big surprise.” She said. Catra fixed her with a piercing glare and she backtracked. “I mean, uh, what about Adora? I thought you said things were good.”

“Things are good. I don’t know, it’s… it’s stupid. Forget it.” Catra said, staring at the ground.

Netossa put a hand on her shoulder. “Hey, I’m not here to judge you, Catra. Whatever it is, you can tell me.”

Catra thought about it, scanning Netossa’s face skeptically, before continuing. “It’s… ugh, fine. So, Perfuma told me that I should… work on gratitude. So, I’ve been practicing, y’know, like, reminding myself about the things I’m grateful for instead of wallowing in all the bad stuff. But with Adora it’s like… I don’t know, it… doesn’t feel like enough? Like I want to… show her how much she means to me. It doesn’t feel like enough to just say it. Ugh, it sounds dumb out loud.”

She looked up at Netossa and instantly regretted saying anything. Netossa had the same look on her face that Bow wore every time Catra sneezed. She rolled her eyes and crossed her arms but Netossa stifled a chuckle and quickly composed herself. “Hey, it doesn’t sound dumb at all. It’s actually really sweet. Why don’t you try, y’know, doing something nice for her?” Netossa said amicably.

“Ugh, that’s the hard part. I don’t know what to do. I’ve never… I mean, like… like what? Just… get her a gift? I’ve already done that. And what kind of gift is going to tell her how much I – “ Catra cut herself off, shaking her head, suddenly embarrassed to be talking about this.

Netossa gave her a soft smile. “That’s a good start. Why don’t you try taking her out?” she said.

Catra stared at her blankly.

“Y’know, like on a date?”

Catra cocked an eyebrow.

“You didn’t have *dates* in the Horde?” Netossa exclaimed.

Catra felt her eye begin to twitch in frustration and a blush spread across her cheeks.

“Ooookay, sit.” Netossa instructed, taking Catra by the shoulders and directing her downward. Netossa sat opposite her in the soft grass of the training field and crossed her legs. “A date is when you take someone you care about to do something you both enjoy. It can be simple, like going out to dinner, eating your favorite food. There’s this place in town that Spinny and I go to all the time, they make a killer – uh, well, that’s not the point. Mostly it’s just about spending time together, talking and getting to know each other.”

Catra listened intently, looking thoughtfully at the ground. “We used to do that. Just go somewhere and do something fun. Just the two of us.” A faint smile crept onto her lips before she furrowed her brow. “But Adora already knows everything about me. We’ve been together our whole lives.”

“Then it should be easy. And that’s not as important as just spending time together. Trust me, I’ve been doing this for a long time. Take her out and show her a good time and she’ll know how you feel.”

Catra did not look convinced. “So what just… eat dinner together? We do that every night, that’s not special.” She said, her scowl returning.

“So *make* it special. Get her a gift. Bring her flowers. Get dressed up, cook her favorite meal! Show her how well you know her and how important she is to you.”

Catra thought about it long and hard before looking Netossa in the eye and asking, "Did… you say there's a nice place here in town?"

Netossa smiled.

"Oh man! This is so nice! Why didn't we ever do anything like this in the Horde?" Scorpia asked, delicately setting down her tea cup.

"We were kind of busy with the whole world domination thing." Catra replied, taking a satisfied sip from her own cup.

They were having lunch on a small balcony in the castle overlooking the gardens of Brightmoon. Catra lounged comfortably in a chair that was far too big for her while Scorpia looked like she was having a hard time fitting her broad frame in an identical chair on the other side of the small table. Scorpia had mostly been in the (former) Fright Zone for the past several weeks, working on reclaiming her family's kingdom from the Horde. It was basically just reconstruction work, redesigning the area, moving things around, renovating a palace that had long since fallen into ruin.

Perfuma had been a great help. The entire region had been overrun by wild plants since the magic had been set free and it was tremendously helpful to have a princess who could use the greenery to move entire buildings if she wanted to. Catra had visited on many occasions to help where she could, mostly with organizing the workers (primarily Horde remnants), requisitioning supplies, and overseeing the redesign. It was nice to be working with Scorpia again. Though Catra had been terrible to her, and though they had talked it out (a few times), it was an ill-kept secret that Catra had always found a sort of solace in Scorpia's company, especially now that the war was over. And it had not escaped Catra's notice that Scorpia and Perfuma would sometimes share blushing glances at one another, or the way their hands lingered ever so slightly every time they touched.

"Yeah, that really kept us busy, huh?" Scorpia said, pulling Catra out of her thoughts.

"Yeah… it did." Catra replied absently, replaying memories of her time as Hordak's second. They didn't bother her so much anymore. Not when she was awake, at least. Lately she found it much easier to… how did Perfuma say it? Dissociate in a healthy way? *These thoughts aren't me,* she reminded herself. *I'm not that person anymore.*

Her pensive silence did not escape Scorpia's notice. "Hey, it wasn't all bad. We had fun, right? And anyway, that's all in the past. We're not those people anymore." Scorpia said with that same dopey, hopeful smile that reminded Catra of Adora.

Catra laughed. "Sounds like you've been talking to Perfuma."

At that, Scorpia blushed lightly and looked nervously down into her tea.

Catra knew that look. She raised an eyebrow and almost surprised herself by asking, “Hey, are you alright?”

Scorpia looked up at her equally surprised before turning away bashfully. “Yeah, I mean… it’s nothing. Probably nothing. I shouldn’t bother you with it.”

Catra blinked before chuckling softly. How the tables had turned. Wasn’t that basically what she had been telling people all morning? She shook her head and said, “Scorpia, I’m not your boss anymore. I’m your friend. Now just spit it out.” Her tone was amiable. She knew that, as hard as it had been, she had felt so much better after coming clean with Perfuma and Netossa. And she was determined to be a better friend, and this is what good friends did, wasn’t it? Help each other through their problems? If anyone deserved a good friend, it was Scorpia.

Scorpia did not answer. Instead she scratched her head with the back of one of her pincers and blushed deeply. Catra suddenly put together the pieces. “It’s about Perfuma, isn’t it?”

Scorpia nearly fell out of her chair and her face turned almost as red as her carapace. “W-what? No, nooo. I mean… yes? I mean… gosh this is so much harder than I thought it’d be.” Scorpia stuttered.

Catra suppressed a laugh. Was she giving relationship advice now? Because she was unquestionably the *wrong* person to ask for that. And yet, Scorpia looked at her with so much… trust. Catra realized that, though Scorpia had easily become fast friends with all of the princesses, she somehow still considered Catra to be one of her closest confidants. The thought filled Catra with a sort of warmth. She had never had a best friend before, excluding Adora. But that was different. With Scorpia there was trust and there was warmth and there was even love, but it was such a different flavor from what she shared with Adora. Catra decided she liked it. She could get used to it. Maybe she could even reciprocate it.

"Scorpia," She began in an uncharacteristically gentle tone. "Hey, I'm… here for you. I promise I won't judge you or get angry or… whatever. Just talk to me. I'm here."

"I don't know," Scorpia started hesitantly. "It's just… Perfuma and I have been working together a lot lately and it's… been really nice. I mean *she's* just so nice and… pretty and she smells like flowers all the time. And I just… get all mushy inside when I think about her and I… I don't have a lot of experience with this and… I don't know, it's… *scary.* I just…" She sighed. "I just care about her so much. And I don't want to… hurt her or lose her or push her away. But I… I feel like I'm going to just snap in half every time she looks at me. And I don't know what to do about that."

Catra listened with patience, though not surprise. It was obvious to anyone who was paying attention how Scorpia and Perfuma felt about each other. Catra smiled a wry smile, hardly believing the

words that spilled from her mouth. “You could try asking her out. Like, on a date.” She said.

Scorpia looked at her blankly.

“A date,” she continued. “Is when you take someone you care about to do something you both enjoy. Like, just ask her to have dinner with you or something, just the two of you. Make her favorite meal. Dress up. Get her flowers… or well, I guess that kind of doesn’t work with the girl who can literally materialize flowers. But you know. Make it special.”

Scorpia’s eyes widened with confusion, then excitement. “Oh, of course! A date! They covered that in Force Captain Orientation.”

Catra opened her mouth to go on but instead gaped at Scorpia for a moment. “Wait, what?!” she exclaimed.

Scorpia laughed heartily, tapping her pincer lightly on the table and wiping a stray tear from her eye. “I’m kidding! I’m just kidding! But man, that one never gets old.” She said, still laughing softly.

Catra could not help herself; she laughed along with Scorpia. She laughed harder than she had in a very, very long time. Was this what having a real friend felt like?

When their laughter had died down, Scorpia looked at Catra, smiling softly. “Hey, thanks, Catra. That’s some really good advice. When did you get so good at this?”

Catra scoffed and looked away. “I might have had a… similar problem. I got some help. I’m just passing it along.” She said, surprising herself again with her own honesty.

Scorpia just looked at her with so much warmth in her eyes. Catra shifted uncomfortably, feeling as though she might melt under that warm gaze.

“Thanks.” Scorpia finally said. “You’re a good friend.”

Catra stood at the edge of the water, scanning the horizon, waiting. She looked up at the early afternoon sun making its way across the sky and began tapping her foot impatiently. When she looked down again, she could see a spec on the horizon, sailing closer and closer at full speed. As she waited, she could start to make out the colorful blue and green sails and the shine off the glistening white bow. When the ship was just a few hundred yards from the shore, the sails came up and she saw a small white rowboat heading toward her. Catra’s heart began to beat anxiously. She had been the one to arrange this meeting, why was she nervous? She took a few breaths to try and calm herself. *In… and out.* Melog bumped against her leg comfortingly and she

rested her hand on their head. After what felt like an eternity, the rowboat finally landed on shore and a short, dark-skinned girl with dreadlocks that now fell down into her face and fancy new seafarer's attire stepped out.

"Ahoy, Force Captain." Lonnie said smugly.

Catra's nervousness was undercut by her amusement as she laughed at the greeting. "Wow, those pirates are really rubbing off on you, huh?" she said, matching Lonnie's tone.

"*Privateers.*" Lonnie corrected closing the distance between them and locking Catra's eyes with a hard stare. After one tense beat, Lonnie smiled and held out her hand. "It's good to see you, Catra."

Catra grasped her hand and let out a startled huff as Lonnie pulled her in for a hug. Catra chuckled. "Since when are you a hugger?" she asked.

Lonnie pulled back, rolling her eyes. "Spending too much time with Sea Hawk does that to people."

Catra just smiled at her and smoothed the ruffled fur on her arms. "It's good to see you, too." She said.

Lonnie rolled her eyes again but could not suppress her own smile. “Careful, Force Captain. I think these princesses might be making you soft.”

Catra scoffed and a self-conscious blush spread over her cheeks. She almost denied it, *almost* shot back a snide remark. But she was on a roll with the whole emotional honesty thing today. Why stop now?

“Yeah, maybe they are.” She replied.

Lonnie’s eyes widened in surprise before she erupted into hearty laughter. “Well, guess that makes two of us.”

Catra smiled. This was going better than she thought. She had been horrible to Lonnie, to all of them. They should hate her. Instead, she kept finding gracious forgiveness everywhere she turned. It was absolutely disorienting, and incredibly gratifying. How strange it was how one good thing had brought her so far.

"Uh, what is that?" Lonnie asked, pointing at Melog, who approached her hesitantly. She cautiously reached out a hand toward them and Melog sniffed it before rubbing its face against it. Lonnie chuckled and pet them gently behind the ears.

"That's Melog. They're, uh... from a different planet." Catra responded.

"Well that's... weird. But nice I guess." she said uncertainly, grinning down at the Krytian. Melog rolled over at Lonnie's touch and she began to rub their belly vigorously.

“How’re Kyle and Rogelio?” Catra asked.

“Good! They keep around that weird imp thing that Hordak had. It’s kind of sweet actually. But sea life really suits us. Mostly we try to keep Sea Hawk from setting our boat on fire and steer him toward setting *other* people’s boats on fire. The seas are more dangerous than ever now that the Horde is gone. A lot of ex-soldiers apparently figured out that there’s a lot of money in pirating. Speaking of money…” Lonnie led with a raised eyebrow.

It was Catra's turn to roll her eyes as she casually pulled out a heavy sack of coins, tossing it to Lonnie.

“You been taking lessons from Double Trouble?” Catra asked amiably.

“Actually, yeah. DT’s been taking a few jobs with us here and there. They also figured out that there’s a lot of money in pirating. Er, privateering.” Lonnie said distractedly, prying open the bag and rifling through the coins before tossing it into her rowboat.

“Oh wow. You guys are really getting around, huh?” Catra said.

“Hah! You have no idea.” Lonnie said, shaking her head. “We’ve been all over since the Horde fell apart. We stayed with Huntara and helped out in the Crimson Waste for a while, paid a visit to Scorpia in the Fright Zone, pretty much been on a tour of Etheria. Have you heard of these things called parties? The Etherians are really into them and they are amazing.”

“You’ll have to tell me about it sometime. We should… have drinks. Catch up.” Catra said, surprising herself again with the words coming out of her mouth today.

Lonnie stared at her before smirking. “Sure, Force Captain. We know where you live. We’ll drop by sometime.”

Catra nodded. “So, the refugees…” she started.

“Are safe on the ship.” Lonnie replied kindly. “They’re excited to help rebuild Sileneas and start new lives there. Most of them are ex-Horde and all they want is a fresh start. Plus, we have a literal boatload of scrap from the Fright Zone to begin building. You wanna come see?” she said, gesturing to the large vessel in the distance.

“Nooo thanks. I’ll just take your word for it.” Catra said, looking at the gentle waves crashing against the shore with absolute dread.

Lonnie laughed. “Suit yourself.”

“Hey,” Catra said after a moment. “Thanks. Y’know, for all this.”

Lonnie scoffed at that. “I mean, it’s not like we’re doing you a favor. And besides it’s… not for you. It’s for them. And… for us.” she paused, looking thoughtfully at the sand. “I mean… everything the Horde taught us was wrong. I guess we’ve known that for a while. We’re just… trying to undo some of the damage we’ve done. And maybe doing that… helps undo some of the damage done to us.”

Catra blinked and then her lips were tugged upward in a soft smile. “Yeah,” she said. “I know what that’s like.”

Lonnie smiled back at her. “Man, it’s weird to see you so… happy. But it’s nice, you know? For a while there, we thought we’d lost you.”

“Yeah, well… I kind of lost myself. But I’m… look, I’m really sorry for… for everything. I treated you guys like garbage and I… I’m sorry.” Catra said, rubbing her arm self-consciously.

“Hah! Wow. Guess Adora’s really been rubbing off on you. In all the right ways.” Lonnie replied with a knowing smirk.

Catra blushed deeply and gaped at her.

Lonnie nearly doubled over at the look on Catra's face. "Relax, Catra. It's not like it's a secret. Sea Hawk won't *shut up* about how you helped save the universe with the power of love." she said, waving her hands in the air dramatically.

Catra whipped her tail back and forth in annoyance.

"Thanks for that, by the way." Lonnie continued, her tone softening. "Y'know, for the whole saving the universe thing. Thanks for… doing the right thing in the end."

Catra met her earnest gaze before averting her eyes, the slightest hint of a smile on her lips. "Yeah, well… didn't do it for you."

Lonnie laughed good-naturedly and gestured back to her rowboat. "I better go. If I'm gone too long Sea Hawk will probably set the ship on fire. But you… you take care of yourself, Catra."

Catra held her smile and nodded. "I will."

Lonnie gave her a fond wave before turning and walking back to her boat, calling over her shoulder, "Say hi to Adora for us!"

"No, no, your fingers are too far up. The note is sharp. Slide them down a bit." Bow said kindly, demonstrating the correct placement on his own lute.

Catra grumbled but did as she was shown and played the chord again.

"Oh." She said with pleasant surprise. "You're right. That does sound better."

Bow smiled broadly and they began to play through their warm up again.

Catra had begun practicing with Bow several weeks ago. It was sort of an accident that turned out to be a tremendous bonding experience for the two of them. On a whim, she had decided to get gifts for all of them, for Bow, Glimmer, and Adora, to show her appreciation for their gracious forgiveness of her past misdeeds and for everything they had done for her since moving to Brightmoon. For Glimmer, she had gotten a small, silver pendant with an etching of Queen Angella on it. On the back she had engraved the words, *One Good Thing.* For Adora, she had bought a swanky new red leather jacket, because *Adora, you've been wearing the same thing for years, you deserve to wear something nice.* Of course, now Adora wore *that* every day. She had, however, redesigned her outfit and was (finally) beginning to develop her own style. She had gotten new, more casual red shoes to match the jacket, and had taken a page from Bow's book

and wore a simple white short sleeve shirt underneath which cut off just below her chest to display her midriff. Catra was certainly not going to complain about that.

But as far as a gift for Bow, Catra had been at a loss. She thought about getting him something archer-y or tech-y, but she found she didn't know nearly enough about those things to make it special. She didn't know nearly enough about *him* to make it special. Catra had been bonding with Glimmer and, obviously, Adora much more easily than she had with Bow, though not for lack of trying. Catra found she just didn't really get Bow at all. So, in an act of desperation, she had approached him practicing his lute and had just come out and said it; that she didn't have any idea what to get him for a gift and that she thought that maybe his gift could just be spending some time together. So, she had bought a lute for herself and humbly (as humbly as she was capable) asked him to teach her to play. Bow had been more enthusiastic about it than she expected and had told her that it was "the perfect gift". She had, of course, asked that he not tell anyone what they were up to, and Bow had graciously agreed to those terms.

So they would steal away every few days to the solitude of the woods just outside of Brightmoon to practice playing their instruments. At first, Catra was horrible at it. She did not understand music. Growing up in the Horde, they didn't really have songs. But after a few sessions, she found she was getting the hang of it, and actually had quite the ear for tones. As they played together today, Bow strummed a few basic chords and Catra played the harmonies, humming along simple melodies.

"Yeah, that's it! You know, you're really a natural. Oh! You should write a song!" Bow exclaimed.

"*Write* a song?" Catra asked, incredulous.

"Yeah! Y'know, like, make up one of your own. So you can play it for people. Express yourself. You can even add lyrics! Like a poem but you sing it with the music." Bow ranted excitedly, automatically explaining the things he wasn't sure Catra would understand. Catra rolled her eyes. "It's a really good way to get your feelings out. Being creative is so important and incredibly rewarding." He continued. "And you can write about whatever you want! It can be something silly like what you had for breakfast or, y'know, you can write about your life. Like, living in Brightmoon, or living in the Fright Zone, or… y'know, you can write how you feel about… the things that happened to you. Oh! Or you could write a love song! You should write a song for Adora!"

Catra's hand twitched and she stummed a cacophonous note. Bow looked at her with one eyebrow raised. Catra sat suspiciously still.

"What?" he asked, eyeing Catra inquisitively.

Catra said nothing. Her ears went flat on her head and she gripped the lute tighter.

Bow stared at her, gauging her guilty expression, before gasping and pointing at her accusingly.

"You already wrote one for her!" he exclaimed.

Catra groaned. Maybe these bonding sessions were backfiring on her. How was it that he already seemed to be able to read her so well?

"Have you played it for her yet?" he asked, nearly jumping out of his seat with excitement.

Catra scowled and repositioned her fingers, finding the right places, and began strumming absently.

"No. It's… not done." She said, averting her gaze.

"AHA! So you *did* write a song for her!" Bow shouted. "You should play it for me! Pleeeease?"

Catra's tail twitched in annoyance and she let out a soft hiss, stilling her hands defiantly.

"Aww, are you just being shy? Come on, Adora's going to love it! Even if it's bad. Which it's not. It's amazing."

"Ugh, you haven't even heard it." Catra growled, but Melog betrayed her grumpiness by rubbing its head fondly against Bow's

leg. Bow smiled and pet Melog gently down their back.

"I know you're afraid of opening up. But everyone already knows you're secretly sweet, so it's really pointless to try to hide it." Bow said with a Bow-equivalent of smugness.

"Not a secret if everyone knows." Catra muttered, then sighed. "I might… I might play it for her tonight. I'm trying to surprise her. With, y'know, something special."

"*Really?*" Bow exclaimed, jumping to his feet. Catra could almost *see* the hearts in his eyes.

She scoffed and looked away, but a small smile began to tug at the corners of her lips.

"Yeah, I'm gonna take her to dinner and get dressed up and… I don't know, do date things."

Bow gasped dramatically and his eyes lit up.

"Catra, you're taking her out on a date?! That's so *sweet*!" he exclaimed.

“Ugh, yes, the secret’s out. I’m actually incredibly sweet. Congratulations, you guys have officially corrupted me.”

Bow did a strange little dance, hardly able to contain himself. Catra did not even try to restrain her laughter.

“You should definitely play her your song. *Nothing* is more romantic than a serenade. It’s *classic*.” Bow said, his tone much more solemn than was called for.

Catra chuckled at him, surprised by how much she was enjoying herself with him. Today had been full of surprises.

“Yeah, alright, I’ll think about it. Now sit down. I’m not here to talk about what I may or may not have planned for Adora tonight.”

“Oh, we are so talking about this.” Bow replied with an impish smirk. “You should definitely play your song for me. So I can, y’know, give you feedback and stuff.”

Catra huffed at him but the hopeful look in his eyes… reminded her too much of Adora. She sighed and positioned her lute in her hands.

“Alright, sit down.” She said before beginning to play a soft, sweet melody.

“Oh! Here, try this one!” Glimmer said excitedly, throwing another suit jacket onto the pile in Catra’s arms.

“Sparkles,” Catra said, barely containing her annoyance. “We’ve been here for almost an hour. Can we just pick something and get out of here?”

They were standing in the royal tailor’s boutique, a large open room with a *lot* of windows and skylights to let in the natural light. In fact, the whole place was made almost entirely of glass. There was one wall toward the back where the fitting and storage rooms were housed. The few opaque walls and tiled floor were trimmed in the trademark Brightmoon white and lavender with splashes of pinks. The wide, circular space was full of sample designs of suits and gowns, blouses and slacks, and everything in between. They had picked out a few and were on their way to the fitting room. Or they would be if Glimmer did not stop every few feet to add another article of clothing to their already too-large pile. Catra didn’t know shopping could be so excruciating.

“I thought you wanted to *make it special.*” Glimmer replied, far too satisfied with herself.

Catra growled at her, imagining cruel and unusual tortures she could inflict upon Bow.

Hide his fancy arrows.

Less than an hour after she had left him in the woods, Glimmer had found her and told her that she was going to help Catra pick out an outfit for her date. It had not been a request*.*

Replace all his shirts with ones that cover his stomach.

"He says you have something *amazing* planned, but he wouldn't tell me about it." Glimmer whined. Well, at least he had kept quiet about the music thing. "But that's fine. I'll just get all the details from Adora tomorrow."

Catra added *shopping with Glimmer* to the list.

Finally, *finally,* they made their way to the dressing rooms and Catra unceremoniously dropped the pile of clothes she was holding on a nearby bench.

"You're going to wrinkle the fabric. This isn't Horde standard issue, Catra. This is *silk*." Glimmer said, setting to work smoothing and reorganizing the pile.

“Can we just get this over with?” Catra pleaded, too exhausted to even be snippy about it.

Glimmer just chuckled and handed Catra the first outfit. “Here, try this one.”

“Finally.” Catra muttered, quickly disappearing behind an elaborately embroidered curtain.

“This is fun. We should do this more often!” Glimmer said, half-teasingly, half-deadly serious.

“Not a chance.” Catra called from behind the curtain.

“Oh come on! You owe me. I didn’t have to come do this for you.” Glimmer said with mock indignation.

She heard Catra’s muffled laughter. “You were *just* complaining about how long and boring your space meeting was. Don’t act like you’re doing me a favor. I didn’t even ask you to come!”

“Yeah, but… aren’t you glad I’m here?”

Catra made an exasperated noise.

“I’m going to take that as a yes.”

“How did you even get out of that anyway? After the way you dragged Adora out of bed this morning, now you’re the one skipping out?” Catra asked.

“I told them I had something really important to do. And this *is* important. My dad and Aunt Casta are covering for me. Besides it’s… not going well. You would not believe how stressful intergalactic politics can be.” Glimmer said dejectedly.

“Oh, I think I have a pretty good idea.” Catra replied, reappearing from behind the curtain.

“Well?” she asked, squirming under Glimmer’s scrutinizing gaze.

The queen tapped her chin with one finger and *hmmm’d* before teleporting away and reappearing a second later with another shirt.

“Try this with those pants.”

Catra could feel her eyebrow begin to twitch. "We're supposed to be narrowing it down, not adding to it." she growled.

"We are going to find the perfect outfit or die trying. Now go put that on." Glimmer commanded.

Catra groaned but did as she was told.

“You know, I never really pictured you as the romantic type.” Glimmer said off-handedly.

“Shows what you know. I’m full of surprises.” Catra replied from behind the curtain.

“Yeah, you are.” Glimmer said thoughtfully. “You surprise me every day. In a good way. I’m… really proud of you, Catra. You’ve come a really long way.”

“Yeah, well, guess we both have.” Catra responded before stepping back out. Glimmer made a twirling gesture with her finger and Catra growled before spinning around.

“Hmmm, no. Not right. Try this.” Glimmer said, handing her another outfit.

“I’m serious, we should do this more often.” Glimmer continued as Catra slinked back behind the curtain. “We don’t have to go shopping but like… this is nice. Spending time together. We

haven’t really gotten any time alone since… well, since Prime’s ship.”

“Hah! Yeah because that’s a time in my life I want to revisit.” Catra replied a little too harshly.

“What? No! I didn’t mean - ”

“I know what you meant, Sparkles. Sorry, I’m just… freaking out a little bit, I guess.”

“You mean, about the date?” Glimmer asked.

“Mostly about the shopping.” Catra growled. “But… yeah, also about the date.”

“Why? It’s such a great idea! Adora’s going to love it. Especially after this meeting. She’s so stressed about everything and this is absolutely perfect to get her mind off of it.”

Catra was silent for a moment before stepping back out. She looked sullenly at the floor. “I guess. I just… I want everything to be perfect because… because she deserves everything to be perfect. And I just… I don’t know. Maybe I’m just overthinking it. It’s… it’s fine. It’s going to be fine.” Catra said, as if she were trying to convince herself of it.

Glimmer stepped forward and put a reassuring hand on her shoulder. "Catra, it's going to be perfect. And even if things don't turn out the way you imagine, it'll be perfect because you'll be together. That's all that really counts."

Catra just shot her a small smile.

Glimmer smiled back at her before looking down at her outfit. "Ugh, no, not that one. Here, try this one." She said, handing Catra another suit. Catra rolled her eyes and disappeared back into the stall.

"You know, this whole changing room thing is so weird. Like you guys have a whole room for… for *privacy.* A big room, too."

"What, you guys didn't have *privacy* in the Horde?" Glimmer asked quizzically.

"Not really. I mean, Force Captains had their own rooms. I guess it was kind of like a privilege. Like a sign of authority. But we didn't have a lot of privacy growing up."

"Well, that explains a lot." Glimmer replied playfully.

Catra laughed. "I'm just saying, this would be over a lot quicker if you weren't so weird about people stripping in front of you."

"It's called *modesty*, Catra. I know, it's a foreign concept to you. And this isn't supposed to be a chore. We're supposed to be having fun! Bonding!"

"Oh yeah. I can definitely feel the bondage." Catra replied dryly. Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"Alright, then what would you have us do? Like, to bond? Everyone knows you and Bow have your secret bonding time. No, that one's too flowery, try this one. And you do that thing with Perfuma, and Netossa, and Scorpia. I want a thing. We need a thing."

"Not a secret if everyone knows." Catra grumbled from changing room. "And I don't… that's not bonding that's… I do those things for me. It's not… it's different."

"Well, what do you like to do for fun?" Glimmer coaxed.

Catra was silent for a long moment. Glimmer heard the sounds of shuffling clothes quiet as Catra thought about it.

"I don't know." She finally said, so softly Glimmer could hardly hear her.

“You don’t know?” Glimmer asked.

“No one’s ever asked me that before.” Catra replied quietly.

Glimmer stared at the fabric that separated them with a sad understanding. “You guys didn’t have a lot of things to do in the Horde, huh?”

Catra stepped out from behind the curtain, looking down at the floor. She shook her head.

They were both silent for a moment. Glimmer ran through the list of things she would do on her time off. Practicing magic with her dad. Cooking with Aunt Casta. Falling asleep in Bow’s arms as he read her a good book. Playing games with him and Adora. Going to parties, celebrating with her friends. She realized with a pang of sorrow that Catra had never actually had any of these things before.

Glimmer offered a small smile and put a gentle hand on her shoulder. “Well there’s tons of stuff to do in Brightmoon. We can try a bunch of different things, until you find something you like. Oh! Maybe that can be our thing!”

Catra blinked at her and let out a chuckle. “Sure, Sparkles. Sounds great.”

Glimmer's smile grew wide at Catra's easy agreement and she could not help herself from pulling her into a tight hug. Catra tensed, but slowly put her arms around the young queen and hugged her back.

"You're going to wrinkle the fabric." Catra said after a moment. Glimmer laughed and pulled away, straightening her jacket.

"Hmmm, this one's not quite right either. Maybe we could try – "

Catra held a hand out, cutting her off. "My turn to choose."

Glimmer watched as Catra stared at their pile before she grabbed a couple simple articles of clothing and disappeared back behind the curtain.

Glimmer took a seat on one of the benches. "You know, I'm really glad you're here." She began earnestly. "If someone had told me a few months ago that we'd be sitting here like this, I would have laughed in their face, but… I don't think it would be as good if we weren't, you know? It wouldn't be… right."

She heard the sound of Catra's muffled chuckle.

"What?" Glimmer asked.

“Nothing, just… Adora said something like that to me once.”

A smile spread across Glimmer’s lips as Catra stepped back out. She gasped quietly and her smile widened.

“That’s the one.” She said with finality.

Adora entered the room with a needy whine, “Catraaa!” Her eyes scanned her surroundings. She quickly spotted the tip of a narrow brown tail silently beckoning from the balcony. Adora walked over to find Catra perched on the balcony rail, her legs crossed in front of her, her arms stretched out at her sides supporting her, her whole body perfectly relaxed. She was looking lazily out over the horizon, bathing in the early evening sun. She did not turn to look at Adora, just flicked her tail back and forth in greeting and murmured a soft, “Hey, Adora.” Adora approached and wrapped her arms around Catra’s waist groaning dramatically. Catra’s hands slid gently over hers and she chuckled lightly. “Aww, what’s wrong?” she asked, amused.

“You were right about the diplomats.” Adora groaned.

“Oh, what was that? Didn’t quite catch it.” Catra said, smugness dripping from every word.

Adora squeezed her playfully. “You were *right*, okay? They were awful and the meeting was long and boring and complicated. Who knew intergalactic politics would be so stressful?”

“Tell me about it.” Catra said with surprising sincerity.

“Just… everything is so… uggggh! It’s just…” Adora sighed, resting her head on Catra’s shoulder. “It’s just been a long day.”

Catra lightly ran her fingers up Adora’s forearm. “What, you don’t want to talk about it?” she teased.

Adora sighed. “I’d rather just forget about it.”

“Well, I can definitely help with that.” Catra replied, her voice velvety soft.

“Yeah, I think you can.” Adora said, gliding her hands up Catra’s stomach. She buried her nose in the soft fur at Catra’s neck and inhaled deeply. “Mmm, you smell good. Wait, Catra did you… did you *shower?*”

“Yup.” Catra said simply, her tail grazing Adora’s leg affectionately.

Adora trailed her nose down Catra’s neck and inhaled again as her hands held Catra tighter. She brushed her lips against Catra’s cheek, planting a soft kiss there.

Catra laughed. “Wow, it really must have been a bad day. You’re never this needy.”

“It really was.” Adora whined, reaching one hand up to Catra’s head, running her fingers through her soft hair.

“Well, I guess now’s a good time to mention I got you something.” Catra said, and Adora could almost hear the smirk on her lips just as Catra could almost hear Adora’s excitement as she raised her head and her grip around her waist loosened.

“What?” Adora asked, incredulous.

Catra finally turned around, and there was indeed a smirk on her lips. “I got you a gift.” She clarified.

Adora looked at her bewildered. “You did *what?*" she asked, hardly containing her excitement. Catra rolled her eyes and pointed behind her.

Adora turned around and walked back into the room, eyeing Catra suspiciously. But then she spotted it. Lying on the bed was a simple white spring dress with gold trim around the waist and shoulders. Sitting on top of the dress was a single, perfect red rose. She didn't know how she hadn't noticed it coming in. Adora gasped excitedly and looked at Catra, but Catra had looked away to resume her sunbathing. Though Catra was playing it cool, Adora noted that her tail was flicking apprehensively. Adora said nothing. She simply smiled and stood by the bed, running her fingers over the soft, light fabric. Catra heard a shuffling, drawers opening and closing, and after a long, excruciating wait, she heard Adora return to the balcony calling a soft, "Catra."

Catra turned her head and nearly fell off the railing. Adora stood before her in the dress, which fit astonishingly well. The fabric was stretchy and light, and it contoured itself to her form. The hem stopped just below her knees and two thin straps ran over her shoulders, holding it in place. It was casual, breathable, but *beautiful*. Catra's eyes wandered down to Adora's feet and saw that she had donned a pair of simple gold sandals, and then back up to Adora's face. She had let her hair down and quickly brushed it from the looks of it. Her bangs were held back by a small gold hairclip. Catra tried and failed to compose words, instead she simply swallowed hard, painfully aware of a bright blush spreading over her cheeks.

It was Adora's turn to be smug. She grinned a wickedly sweet grin, approached Catra, and gently stroked the soft fur down her face.

"Cat got your tongue?" she whispered.

Catra quickly regained her senses. “The cat’s about to have your tongue.” She breathed. It was all the encouragement Adora needed. She leaned in and their lips collided in an urgent kiss. After a long moment, Catra pulled away, catching her breath. “Guess that means you like it.” She said with a satisfied smile, the smugness in her voice being drowned out by soft adoration.

“I love it.” Adora said gently. “I love *you.*” She leaned in to Catra’s neck and began to trail soft kisses there.

Catra felt her hair stand on end and her heart pound in her chest. She wrapped her arms around Adora, her fingers gliding over her exposed shoulder blades, the tips of her claws trailing gently down her back.

“Mmmm, Adora, don’t make me tear this off of you.” She whispered. “Not before I take you out in it.”

“You mean take me out *of* it?” Adora asked distractedly, her mind focusing on her hungry work at Catra’s neck.

Catra laughed. “No, you idiot, I’m taking you out tonight.” Adora leaned back, looking at her with surprise. “To dinner.” She clarified.

“What like… like a date? Catra… are you taking me out on a *date?”* she said in astonishment.

“Ugh, yes, you can call it a date.” Catra said, her smile betraying the exaggerated roll of her eyes.

“Wait… *really?”* Adora said with more excitement than Catra thought was called for. It delighted her anyway.

“Yes, dummy. Now are you going to let go of me so I can get dressed?” Catra asked, placing her hands on Adora’s and gently prying them off of her.

Adora just stared at her. Catra stood and placed one slender finger on her chest, trailing it over her collarbone. “Stay. Don’t look.” she commanded. Adora dumbly did as she was told as Catra leisurely walked back into the room. After another excruciatingly long wait, Adora heard Catra’s soft footsteps behind her and felt a claw tap her lightly on the shoulder. She turned and gaped.

The outfit Catra had chosen was a simple deep red button up shirt and black slacks that looked like they were tailored to her figure. The long sleeves of the shirt were rolled up to the elbow and the top few buttons were left undone. Her hair was slicked back, not like it had been on Prime’s ship, but sloppily, casually. She did not wear shoes but opted instead for simple black foot coverings that only hid the arch of her feet. Adora could only stare.

“What?” Catra said, walking over briskly, her hands in her pockets. When she stood before Adora, she brushed one long nail delicately under Adora’s chin. “Cat got your tongue?”

Adora did not waste time with a snarky remark. She raised her hands to Catra's waist and pulled her in for a long, searing kiss.

Catra pulled away reluctantly and could not help but run her eyes over Adora again and again. She suddenly had a new appreciation for the term *breathtaking*.

"C'mon," she said finally, touching her nose to Adora's. "We're going to be late."

End Notes

If anyone wants to write the date night continuation, feel free. I'm almost certainly not going to. I'm not too keen on writing a gushy date night fic. Or if you want to collab with me on it, that could be fun. I could use some writey friends.

Also if anyone wants to draw Adora in her new duds or pirate Lonnie, please do so and send it to me.

Anyway, after that last one I thought I'd toss y'all some sweetness and fluff. Lord knows y'all deserve it.

As always, feel free to drop me prompts or ideas for more. I've got one more already written but I'm not sure where to go from there. Thanks for reading! And thanks for all the support! These have been very well received and I'm so thrilled you all enjoy them!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!